

In-Class Discussion

EN 601.124: The Ethics of Artificial Intelligence and Automation

Department of Computer Science, April 8th 2026





Sycophantic AI increases attitude extremity and overconfidence

In the first experiment, the authors measured several main outcome variables, such as attitude extremity, certainty, and enjoyment. What other KPIs could have been useful to quantify and why (name at least 3)?



**Sycophantic AI increases attitude extremity
and overconfidence**

**What does it say about society when the
agreeable AI is seen as less biased than the
control? How can we begin to open users to
the idea of contradictory beliefs being
unbiased? How can AI contribute to this?**



In experiment 3, the disagreeable fact-providing chatbot was perceived as slightly less biased than the disagreeable non-fact-providing chatbot.

Why might this be the case? Individuals also enjoyed fact providing chatbots more than non-fact providing chatbots. Why? How do you anticipate feeling after interacting with a disagreeable chatbot vs. a sycophantic chatbot?





Let's try it out:

Describe a social conflict that you or someone they know experienced (that they feel comfortable sharing) and prompt different chatbots for advice.

Copy the output messages from these chatbots to keep track and label them as sycophantic or validating.



Let's try it out:

Describe a social conflict that you or someone they know experienced (that they feel comfortable sharing) and prompt different chatbots for advice.

Now: Ask a teammate to answer the same questions (role play a bot)





Steering

Explain the activation steering equation found in section 3.2. How does that work? What is a residual stream activation? How does the scalar steering coefficient impact the speed at which the model adopts a personality?



Individually:

Write a mock 1 page google doc e.g., a one page letter to their congressman outlining technically how companies can control personality (like explaining technically how it works).

Outline why the congressman should take this seriously based on concrete evidence (numbers) from the papers introduced either M or W this week (see website for links).

List what policy you propose. Policies should be different within group members.

